



THE UNIVERSITY OF
MELBOURNE

CURRENT STUDENTS IA · LIFECYCLE JOURNEYS

Lifecycle journeys & moments

Where the student experience breaks across stages — six personas and four high-stakes moments. June 2026.

University of Melbourne · June 2026

The University of Melbourne acknowledges the Traditional Owners of the unceded land on which we work, learn and live, and pays respect to their Elders, past and present, and to Indigenous Australians today.

Ten end-to-end traces — six personas and four high-stakes moments — through the University's web estate, composed from the path-level link graph and the prospective + current-student deep-dives. The question is not "is each stage good?" but "does the journey hold together as a real student lives it?" June 2026.

Executive summary

Analysed stage by stage, the estate looks like a set of mostly-competent parts. Traced as a **journey**, it tells a harder story: the experience breaks at the **joints** — the transitions between stages that no team owns. A school-leaver applies on an external government site and crosses into the current estate on one cold link; an international postgraduate navigates a visa-compliance chain forked across three live trees with zero action links on its highest-risk pages; an at-risk student hits two competing versions of "support" and finds counselling on a page branded "Academic Skills Unit"; and at the end, a graduate is handed to the alumni relationship by essentially nothing (~97 contextual links, none from a completion page).

Two things make this more than a list of gaps. First, **the decisive action is always behind a wall** — every journey's most important step happens in my.unimelb, Canvas, eStudent or a form, so the public estate can only ever *describe* the thing the student needs to *do*. Second, **fragmentation is regressive**: the journeys that break hardest are the international, equity/Indigenous, HDR and in-crisis ones — the students with the least margin to absorb a hunt across five-to-eight systems. The fix is the same connective work the current- and prospective-student analyses point to, now aimed explicitly at the transitions: **own the joints** — build the apply→enrol and graduate→alumni bridges, collapse the parallel trees a moving student trips over, surface the behind-login actions, and make the high-stakes moments panic-findable.

What breaks across the lifecycle — six patterns

Tracing ten journeys end-to-end exposes faults that no single-stage view can see — they live in the **joints between stages**, which is exactly where no one owns them.

- 1. The decisive action is always behind a wall.** Every journey terminates its decisive step — apply, enrol, pay, book, submit special consideration, vary a study load — in VTAC, eStudent, my.unimelb, Canvas or a *.app form. The public estate *describes* the action; it never *is* the action. The student crosses a login boundary at the most important moment, and the public side can't confirm the handoff works.
- 2. The joints between stages are the weakest links.** The stages are mostly well-built; the *transitions* are thin or absent — apply→enrol is 373 contextual links, graduate→alumni is ~97 (0 from completion pages), and the support handoffs scatter. The journey is a row of good rooms with broken doorways.
- 3. The hub's parallel URL trees fork the journey mid-stride.** A student in motion hits /support-and-wellbeing vs legacy /student-support, three visa trees, three fee trees, three SEDS trees — the mid-migration debt is experienced as *journey breakage*, not just duplication.
- 4. The most vulnerable journeys break the hardest.** The HIGH-severity traces are international (immigration consequence), equity/Indigenous (least able to absorb fragmentation), HDR (off-estate spine), and the at-risk student (in crisis). The best-served is the domestic school-leaver. Fragmentation is regressive — it costs the most to those with the least margin.
- 5. Domain-hopping is the norm, often onto off-brand or off-estate hosts.** Every journey crosses 5–8 distinct systems; several land on hosts branded as something else (counselling on a page titled "Academic Skills Unit") or off the estate entirely (gradresearch, studentit, Murrup Barak).
- 6. The high-stakes "moments that matter" are the worst-served.** Census (canonical → 404), financial hardship (~5 pages), special consideration (scattered), visa breach (0 action links) — the panic moments where an error costs money, progress or a visa are precisely the ones the estate handles least well.

The lifecycle seam map

Transition	Health	Evidence
discover → apply	broken	forks to 3 systems (VTAC / eStudent / CRM); no single "Apply"

Transition	Health	Evidence
apply → enrol	weak	study→students = 373 contextual links; cold for all but domestic VTAC UG
enrol → study	opaque	the action is in my.unimelb behind login
study → seek support	fragmented	parallel hub trees + off-brand delivery host
support → act	invisible	special con / leave / hardship actions behind login/forms
progress → leave/withdraw	broken	scattered + the census-dates canonical is /page-not-found
complete → graduate	partial	clean apply-to-graduate spine, but split across two URL trees
graduate → alumni	severed	~97 contextual links, 0 from completion pages — nav-only

Persona journeys

Domestic undergraduate (school leaver) [MEDIUM] • persona

The best-served journey — yet it still hands off to an external admissions site to apply and crosses into the current estate on a single cold link.

The journey. Discovers a course on study.unimelb (/find/courses, a 7-tab micro-site) → checks entry requirements (deep-links to the Handbook, a different platform) → applies via VTAC (vtac.edu.au, an external government admissions centre — ~75 outbound links) → receives an offer → accepts → enrolls in my.unimelb (behind login) → follows a single 'Get Started at Melbourne' link across to students.unimelb → orientation → studies (subjects, timetable, results — all transacted in my.unimelb).

Where it breaks

- The apply step leaves the University estate entirely for vtac.edu.au; the prospective site does not own the application.
- No compare tool at the decision point — three shortlisted courses = three 7-tab micro-sites open by hand.
- Course detail (subjects/structure) requires a platform-switch to the Handbook mid-decision.
- The offer→enrol crossover rides the thin study.unimelb→students.unimelb seam (373 contextual links estate-wide); domestic VTAC undergrads are the only cohort that get a genuine guided 'you got in, here's next'.
- Everything decisive (enrol, pay, results) is in my.unimelb behind login — the public estate only describes it.

Systems traversed. ~6: study.unimelb → vtac.edu.au (external) → my.unimelb (auth) → students.unimelb → handbook.unimelb → faculty site.

The fix. Build the offer→enrol bridge for all students (not just VTAC UG); add a compare tool; pull Handbook course-structure into the study.unimelb course view.

International postgraduate (coursework) [HIGH] • persona

The highest-consequence journey and the most tangled — the visa/CoE/OSHC compliance chain is forked across three live trees and the highest-risk pages link to zero action forms.

The journey. Discovers a course → applies via the walled eStudent eApplications portal → offer → pays a tuition deposit → conditional then full CoE → applies for a student visa → arranges OSHC → arrives → enrolls → must maintain study-load to stay visa-compliant → seeks support → graduates → (alumni, nav-only).

Where it breaks

- The application is a walled portal (eStudent / TechnologyOne) the prospect cannot evaluate from the catalogue.
- The CoE/visa/OSHC compliance chain exists as THREE live trees on students.unimelb — canonical /support-and-wellbeing, deprecated /student-support, AND a publicly-indexed /sandbox/2026-uplifts draft — and 11 faculties link the deprecated tree.
- OSHC is authored under 4 different path variants on the hub.
- The two highest-immigration-risk pages ('manage enrolment changes that affect your visa', 'reduced study load') link to ZERO transactional forms — a find→act break with immigration consequences.

- Same thin apply→enrol handoff (373), then the graduate→alumni end is nav-only (~97 contextual links, 0 from completion pages).

Systems traversed. ~8: study.unimelb → eStudent portal (auth) → my.unimelb → students.unimelb (3 visa trees) → services.unimelb → forms.your → faculty → www.unimelb/alumni.

The fix. Designate ONE canonical visa/compliance tree, 301 the deprecated + delete the sandbox draft, repoint the 11 faculties, and wire the highest-risk pages directly to the action forms. Treat first — the cost of error is visa cancellation.

HDR / research candidate [HIGH] · persona

The candidature lifecycle is real but scattered: its system of record sits off the crawled estate while ~8 faculties re-host the same content — including byte-identical clones.

The journey. Discovers a research degree on study.unimelb (only ~6 prospective research-degree pages) → applies via gradresearch/faculty → candidature → milestones → supervision → thesis → examination → completion → research alumni (1 page).

Where it breaks

- The canonical owner gradresearch.unimelb ('Graduate Research Hub') sits OUTSIDE the crawled student estate — the journey's spine is off to the side.
- Education and MDHS re-host the candidature lifecycle BYTE-IDENTICAL (Jaccard 1.0); ~8 faculty CMSes each carry their own copy under different URL trees.
- The research paradox: the faculties with the largest research estates (MDHS 63 research pages) carry the LEAST HDR-student support (1 page) — the strongest research identity, the weakest research-student journey.
- The prospective PhD funnel is near-absent (6 pages) and research-alumni is 1 page — the journey is broken at both ends.
- Career support for graduate researchers is a stub linking out.

Systems traversed. ~6: study.unimelb → gradresearch.unimelb (off-estate) → faculty CMSes (×8) → students.unimelb → my.unimelb.

The fix. Make gradresearch.unimelb the single system of record; 301 the byte-identical faculty clones to it; connect the prospective-PhD and research-alumni ends to close the research lifecycle.

Equity / low-SES / Indigenous student [HIGH] · persona

The highest-equity-stakes journey: the cohorts least able to absorb fragmentation hit the most of it — a forked disability-registration wizard and an Indigenous service with zero presence on the hub.

The journey. Enters via Access Melbourne / special-entry (study.unimelb) → enrolls → registers with Student Equity & Disability Services (SEDS) → seeks Indigenous support (Murrup Barak) → seeks financial support → studies.

Where it breaks

- SEDS is forked across THREE parallel URL trees on the hub and the 4-step registration wizard (prepare→register→create-plan→action-plan) exists on only ONE of them — yet 12 external domains link disabled students to the two hubs that LACK the wizard.
- Indigenous students have ZERO Indigenous-specific pages on students.unimelb; Murrup Barak lives on a separate uncrawled domain and support is scattered across 4 destinations (murrupbarak, indigenousknowledge, Wilin Centre, indigenousscholarships.com.au) with a www-twin and inconsistent anchors.
- Financial-hardship support is ~5 pages — thin for the cohort most likely to need it.
- Every support action ultimately sits behind a my.unimelb / form wall.

Systems traversed. ~7: study.unimelb → students.unimelb (3 SEDS trees) → murrupbarak (off-estate) → indigenousknowledge → scholarships.unimelb → services.unimelb → forms.your.

The fix. Collapse SEDS to one canonical tree carrying the wizard (301 the rest), repoint the 12 external links, give Indigenous students a genuine hub presence, and thicken hardship support — prioritise because the equity cost is highest.

Online / professional / micro-credential learner [MEDIUM] · persona

The non-traditional learner falls between the two estates — courted by prospective marketing but with no clear current-student home once enrolled.

The journey. Discovers short courses / microcredentials (110) / professional development (37) / single-subject study (5) on [study.unimelb/study-with-us](#) → enrolls → studies online (Canvas, behind login) → earns a credential.

Where it breaks

- No clear 'current student' home for non-award learners: study-with-us markets them, but [students.unimelb](#) is built around award-course students — the learner is orphaned between estates after enrolling.
- Single-subject study is 5 pages; the micro-credential pathway is thin and prospective-only.
- The actual learning happens in Canvas/LMS behind login; the public estate has almost no current-experience layer for this cohort.
- No connection from the micro-credential to a pathway INTO an award course (the upsell the funnel should want).

Systems traversed. ~5: [study.unimelb/study-with-us](#) → enrol → Canvas/LMS (auth) → [students.unimelb](#) (no clear home) → credential.

The fix. Give non-award and online learners a defined current-learner home and a clear micro-credential→award pathway; bridge study-with-us to a current-experience layer instead of dropping them after enrolment.

At-risk / struggling student [HIGH] · persona

At the moment a student most needs the estate to work, it fragments hardest — support scattered across parallel hub trees and off-brand hosts, with every action behind a wall.

The journey. Is failing / flagged at-risk → checks academic progress (unsatisfactory progress) → applies for special consideration → hits a wellbeing crisis → looks for financial hardship help → considers leave of absence / withdrawal → re-enrolls or exits.

Where it breaks

- Support is split across the hub's parallel trees (/support-and-wellbeing vs legacy /student-support) — a panicking student hits two competing versions of the same help.
- Counselling/health DELIVERY is on [services.unimelb](#), a shared host branded 'Academic Skills Unit' (614×) far more than 'Counselling' (39×) — the wellbeing link lands on an off-brand page.
- Special consideration + academic-progress content is scattered across trees and faculties; the application action sits behind [specialconsideration.app](#) / [my.unimelb](#).
- Withdrawing touches the census-date consequence — and the census-dates page canonicalises to /page-not-found.
- Financial hardship is ~5 pages; the request funnels into one opaque form (SID params).
- Across this single help-seeking episode the student crosses 5-6 hosts, several off-brand or behind login.

Systems traversed. ~6: [students.unimelb](#) (2-3 trees) → [services.unimelb](#) → [specialconsideration.app](#) → [my.unimelb](#) → [safercommunity.unimelb](#) → [forms.your](#).

The fix. Build one 'I need help now' front door that collapses the parallel trees, names the delivery services consistently, and surfaces the actions (special con, leave, hardship) directly — the journey where consolidation matters most.

Moments that matter

Census date & withdrawal deadline [HIGH] · moment

The single highest financial-stakes moment, and the metadata on its most important page is broken.

The journey. A student weighing whether to drop a subject needs to know the census date, the fee/academic consequence of withdrawing before vs after it, and how to act — fast.

Where it breaks

- The census-dates page carries `canonical=/page-not-found` — the authoritative date page tells search engines it doesn't exist.

- Fee/census content is split across three parallel hub trees (/course-admin, /your-course, /admin/fees) and reverse-funnelled to the prospective site (363 fee pages on study.unimelb vs ~17 on the hub).
- The action — withdraw before census — happens in my.unimelb behind login.
- Get it wrong and the student pays a full subject's fees and/or takes an academic fail.

Systems traversed. ~4: students.unimelb (3 fee trees) → study.unimelb (reverse-funnel) → my.unimelb → ask.unimelb FAQ.

The fix. Fix the canonical, collapse the fee trees to one enrolled-student home, and put the census date + consequence + the withdraw action on one page.

Special consideration & failing a subject [HIGH] • moment

The extension/appeal moment under stress is spread across the hub's competing trees and the faculties, with the action behind a form wall.

The journey. A student who is unwell or failing needs to apply for special consideration / a deferred exam / a remark, or respond to an unsatisfactory-progress flag — quickly and under pressure.

Where it breaks

- Special consideration and academic-progress content is scattered across the parallel hub trees and re-stated by faculties — no single authoritative path.
- The application action sits behind specialconsideration.app / my.unimelb — the public page describes it but doesn't transact it.
- Unsatisfactory-progress (the show-cause moment) is a high-anxiety legal-ish process with fragmented guidance.
- A stressed student must navigate the estate's fragmentation precisely when least able to.

Systems traversed. ~5: students.unimelb (multiple trees) → faculty → specialconsideration.app → my.unimelb → exams pages.

The fix. One canonical special-consideration + academic-progress path with the application action surfaced directly, consistent across faculties.

Financial hardship & emergency support [HIGH] • moment

A student in genuine crisis meets one of the thinnest, hardest-to-find corners of the estate.

The journey. A student who cannot pay rent / fees / eat looks for emergency grants, fee remission, hardship bursaries, emergency accommodation or food relief.

Where it breaks

- Hardship is ~5 pages and 'bursary' ~2 — minimal coverage for a high-consequence need.
- Emergency support is scattered across wellbeing, scholarships, and student-financial-aid (on the off-brand services.unimelb host).
- The request funnels into a single forms.your form with opaque SID query parameters.
- No prominent, panic-findable 'I'm in financial crisis' entry — the student in crisis is the least able to hunt.

Systems traversed. ~5: students.unimelb → services.unimelb (financial aid) → scholarships.unimelb → forms.your → emergency providers.

The fix. Create a single, prominent emergency/hardship front door that aggregates grants, remission, accommodation and food relief, with the request form one click away.

Visa breach / enrolment-load compliance [HIGH] • moment

The moment a study-load change risks a student's visa, the estate offers forked guidance and no path to act.

The journey. An international student whose reduced study load or enrolment change could breach their visa condition needs to understand the rule and act before it's too late.

Where it breaks

- The CoE / visa-condition / reduced-study-load chain is forked across three live trees (canonical, deprecated, sandbox draft).

- 11 faculties link the deprecated tree — so a student arriving from their faculty lands on the wrong guidance.
- The highest-immigration-risk pages link to ZERO transactional forms — the student is told they may breach their visa with no in-page way to act.
- The consequence is immigration enforcement, not inconvenience.

Systems traversed. ~5: faculty → students.unimelb (3 visa trees) → my.unimelb → forms.your / *.app → external (immigration).

The fix. Consolidate to one canonical compliance tree, repoint the 11 faculties, and wire the risk pages to the enrolment-variation / study-load action forms.

*Composed from `analysis/prospective-experience-profiles.json`, `analysis/student-services-profiles.json`, `analysis/improvements-register.md`, and the contextual link graph in `analysis/full-scrape/`. The authenticated core (my.unimelb, Canvas, eStudent, .app forms) and off-estate sites (gradresearch, studentit, Murrup Barak) are uncrawled — claims about them are inferred from outbound links.